Figure Out What Any Care Arrangement for Dad Would Have to Provide

Four prompts to turn what Dad needs into plain requirements, see what staying home would take, ask about the future, and know what a provider still has to confirm.

Where you are

Dad can't manage the way he was, and the family is already saying words like “assisted living” and “home care” as if they were answers. You're being asked to decide between names before anyone has written down what the care actually has to do.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not diagnose, assess safety, or decide. Bring clinical questions to a clinician, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What you'll have at the end

You can say what any arrangement for Dad has to provide, what staying home would require of the family, and what you'd need a provider or a professional to confirm before going further.

A one-page sheet: What the care has to cover, What matters to Dad, What home would take, and Questions a provider or professional must answer.

Before you start

- Your notes on what Dad needs help with and when, even if they're scattered across texts and a notebook.
- Anything Dad has said about where he wants to live.
- The hospital or doctor's instructions, if there are any. If you only have the notes, start there.

PROMPT 1

Translate the needs into plain requirements

WHY THIS MATTERS

Settings get chosen by name because the name is easy to say. The hard part is writing down what the care has to do, hour by hour, and that is what every setting must be measured against.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Your notes on what Dad needs help with, including the small things.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is what my father needs help with right now, as best I can describe it:

> [PASTE YOUR NOTES]
>
> Turn this into a table of requirements with four columns: WHAT HAS TO HAPPEN, HOW OFTEN, WHO DOES IT NOW, and WHAT KIND OF SKILL IT TAKES (anyone, a trained aide, a nurse, or not sure). Write each row as a task, not as a type of care. Do not name a care setting, suggest where he should live, or add needs I didn't describe. At the end, list anything in my notes that was too vague to turn into a row.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A list of tasks you could read to a stranger and have them understand what a day of Dad's care involves.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Fix the vague rows by watching or asking over the next day or two.

PROMPT 2

Add up what staying home would take

WHY THIS MATTERS

Home is the familiar option, so families often skip the arithmetic. Someone has to do each task on the list, at the hour it's needed, and that someone has a job, a drive, or their own health to think about.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The requirements table from Prompt 1 and an honest list of who in the family is available, and when.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here are my father's care requirements and who in the family is actually available to help:
>
> [PASTE THE TABLE FROM PROMPT 1]
>
> [PASTE WHO IS AVAILABLE AND WHEN]
>
> Lay out a week as a grid: mornings, daytime, evenings, overnight, each day. Mark which blocks have a family member available, which tasks fall in blocks with nobody, and which tasks the family has said they can't or won't do. Then list what outside help would have to cover, described as hours and tasks, not as a service name. Do not conclude whether he can stay home. That is for the family to work out with professional input, not for you.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

The hours and tasks nobody in the family can cover. That is the real size of the question.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Show the grid to the relatives on it and ask whether it's true.

PROMPT 3

Ask what happens when things change

WHY THIS MATTERS

The arrangement that fits today may not fit in six months. The question to ask about any setting, including home, is how it handles more care, and families rarely ask it until they need to.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The requirements table and anything you know about Dad's condition that may change.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> My father's care requirements are below, along with what I know about how his condition may change:
>
> [PASTE THE REQUIREMENTS TABLE]
>
> [PASTE WHAT YOU KNOW ABOUT LIKELY CHANGES]
>
> Write the questions a family should put to any care arrangement, whether that is help at home or a residential setting, about how changing needs would be handled. Group them under: IF HE NEEDS MORE HANDS-ON HELP, IF HIS MEMORY CHANGES, IF HE NEEDS NURSING, and IF HE HAS TO MOVE AGAIN. Phrase each as a question we would ask a provider or a professional. Do not answer them, predict his course, or say which setting handles change best.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

Questions that would feel awkward to ask on a tour. Those are the ones worth keeping.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Mark the three questions you most want answered before any decision is made.

PROMPT 4

Put it on one page for the people who can confirm it

WHY THIS MATTERS

You now have requirements, the shape of home, and the questions about change. The last job is to put them where a provider, a doctor, or your care consultant can see what you need confirmed.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Everything from Prompts 1 to 3, plus anything Dad has said about where he wants to be.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is what I've gathered about my father's care and what he has said about where he wants to live:
>
> [PASTE THE RESULTS OF PROMPTS 1 TO 3]
>
> [PASTE WHAT DAD HAS SAID]
>
> Give me one page with four headings: WHAT THE CARE HAS TO COVER, WHAT MATTERS TO DAD, WHAT HOME WOULD TAKE, and QUESTIONS A PROVIDER OR PROFESSIONAL MUST ANSWER. Under the last heading, tag each question with who answers it: a provider, his doctor, a care consultant, or the family. Do not recommend a setting, rank arrangements, name any facility or agency, or say whether home is safe. Keep his own words where I've given them.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A page that says what Dad needs without saying where he should go.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Hold onto this page. The next step starts from it.

Start with Dad's full picture

A care setting can only be judged against needs that have been written down. The care interview goes through Dad's situation area by area and produces a Family Care Profile, which is the document your care consultant works from when she talks through settings with you.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›